

Deciphering the jargon

General-purpose LED bulbs are termed as A-line bulbs, where 'A' indicates the bulb's shape (usually pear-like). One-eighth of the number following the letter 'A' denotes the bulb width. So, A19 implies a bulb with a width of $19/8 = 2.375$ inches. The width is variable (A19, A21, etc.).

The base of the bulb has different notations depending on the screw type. Generally, Indian standard bulbs have a B22 base, meaning a 'B' (bayonet) type screw with 22mm diameter base. Standard North American screw type is E26, i.e., 'E' (Edison) type screw with 26mm diameter base. Standard European screw type is E27.

There are other bulb categories as well, including flood lights, spot lights and candle lights—all having separate application areas.

POWER CONSUMPTION (WATTS) OF CONVENTIONAL BULBS AND EQUIVALENT LUMENS IN LED BULBS

Watts	Lumens
20	200
40	450
60	800
75	1100
100	1600

ured based on temperature notations in Kelvin (K). LED bulbs can emit different ranges of light colour—warm white (2700K to 3300K), neutral white (4000K to 5000K) and cool white (above 5000K). Unicolour bulbs can emit light only at a single CCT, and thus need to be selected accordingly.

LED bulbs can also be dimmed based on the circuitry, subject to compatibility of the bulb with the available dimmer switch.

Market checklist

The Indian market is flooded with cheap LED products of less-than-standard quality. Buying the wrong product leads to losses in the long run. Here are a few pointers to ensure you choose the right LED bulb.

Buy lumens, not watts. The age-old assumption is that the higher the consumption wattage marked on a bulb, the higher is its output. Well, that might have been true for the old incandescents but for LEDs that concept is history. In reality, higher lumens output and lower consumption wattage is the ideal combination to look for in a bulb. Thus, a bulb

marked to produce a certain lumens output by consuming, for example, 7 watts, is better than a bulb producing the same lumens consuming 10 watts of power.

If you intend to replace your incandescent bulb or CFL with an LED bulb, you can use the table given here to choose the LED bulb's correct lumens in accordance with your existing bulb's wattage.

Warranty period. Good-quality LED bulbs come with a warranty period of at least three years. Anything less than that should raise concerns about the fairness of the deal.

Certifications. According to Vinay Mahendru, director, Eon Electric, "It is essential for the customer to check for BIS certification while purchasing an LED bulb to be sure about the product quality." BIS certification for a product is awarded by the Bureau of Indian Standards as a guarantee of its safety, quality and reliability.

About the average price of an LED bulb, Mahendru confirmed, "In the Indian market, a 9W LED bulb costs around ₹ 150 to the end users."

The final advice

LED bulbs are costlier than conventional bulbs and return on investment depends completely on their extent of use. Bulbs installed in offices run for nine to ten hours every day or even longer, ensuring full utilisation of the bulbs and a consequent return on the investment made. If you want to install LED bulbs in your home or temporary office, anticipate first the extent of LED bulb use. **EFY**

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